PART THREE

Managing Individuals

9.

Delegating with Confidence

Delegating is one of your most important responsibilities as a manager. Your role is to ensure the right people are doing the right work, at the right time, and in the right way. That includes what work you'll do and what each member of your team is responsible for. The most effective managers spend less time "doing" and more time planning work assignments, organizing resources, and coaching people to achieve their best possible results. While most managers never get away from "doing" altogether, the goal is to ensure that your work is high priority and high impact for the organization.

Still, it can be hard to give up control over specific tasks, especially if you like doing them and you're good at them, even if your workload is overwhelming. You may also hesitate to delegate an item that's something of a stretch assignment for your staff (won't it just be easier if you do it yourself?). And once do you make an assignment, you must maintain accountability for the work without crossing over into micromanagement. Chances are you also worry about overburdening your very busy team members.

In this chapter, you'll learn *why* it is important to delegate, how to make a delegation plan and share it with your employees, how to track progress and provide support, and how to avoid the most common managerial mistakes.

Benefits of delegation

One of the common misconceptions managers have about delegation is that delegating signals weakness—that they should be able to do everything on their own. But effective delegation can have real benefits for you, your people, and your organization.

When you delegate, you remove tasks from your to-do list that others are qualified to handle. This gives you more time to focus on activities that require your unique skills and level of authority: planning, business analysis, coordinating operations, obtaining resources, addressing personnel issues, and developing your employees. If you can give these core tasks the time they require, your performance *and* your job satisfaction will improve.

For your staff, delegation creates new opportunities for growth and boosts motivation. Imagine that you ask an employee to prepare the agenda for an upcoming meeting. The person will help set goals for the meeting, draw up a blueprint for the conversation, recruit presenters and seek advice from other stakeholders, and create and circulate relevant materials—tasks that may seem routine or bothersome to you, but will give your direct report increased visibility and new insight into how your company works.

From an organizational perspective, delegation helps you maximize your company's resources and improve productivity. The math here is simple: if you make the most of each team member's abilities, you'll maximize the group's output. Less simple are the intangible benefits you'll create in terms of group dynamics. Trust will deepen across the whole team—trust in you, for extending meaningful opportunities to grow and have influence; trust in each other, for performing well and getting results; and trust in themselves, for mastering new challenges.

Developing a delegation plan

Once you have identified a task to delegate, start by making a written delegation plan *before* you talk to your employee. It should detail everything from why the assignment is important to the deadlines involved.

Making a good plan is important. If you assign a task to someone who lacks the right skill set, for example, you're setting both of you up for failure and disappointment. Or if you fail to make accommodations for an employee's extra-heavy workload, you might push him into burnout. And without a clear, comprehensive description, you don't know that the employee will actually do the work you need done. A written delegation plan creates a record that you and your staff can refer back to as the work progresses. You can use it to hold your employee accountable, troubleshoot if the project goes awry (did you describe the work inaccurately?), and bolster your argument for the employee's promotion.

Here's how to create your delegation plan.

Step 1: Decide what to delegate

To decide what you should delegate, assess your workload and identify tasks, projects, or functions that don't require your specific set of skills and authority. Identify work that could easily be done by other staff members or outside resources with a minimum of coaching or on-the-job training.

If a task, project, or function is too important to delegate to someone else, think about sharing responsibility. You may be able to subdivide work so you handle one part and delegate the rest.

Avoid delegating if:

- You can't precisely explain what you want the other person to do. If you can't articulate what problem needs to be solved or what exactly needs to be done, it's best to wait to assign responsibility for the work until you can clarify these things.

- You'll put your own development or ability to lead in jeopardy by delegating. For example, suppose you need to develop your interpersonal skills so you can interact more effectively with your team members. Avoid delegating work that requires extensive interaction with your team, such as leading meetings or talking with employees to learn about their career goals.

- You'll undermine a project's success by delegating. For instance, let's say you have extensive experience developing marketing plans and you were hired for these skills. Your unit is launching a major new product line, and the marketing plan will prove critical to the line's success. You decide to retain responsibility for defining the strategic elements of the plan, but you delegate the tactical components.

Step 2: Why—*clarify your purpose*

Why are you delegating work? Think about the specific problems you want to solve or benefits you want to achieve. Questions to consider include:

- Why do you want to delegate *this* particular slice of work?
- How will delegating affect your own work experience? Will it lighten your workload, lower stress, or let you focus on other managerial responsibilities?
- What impact do you want this assignment to have on your employee? In what sense is this work an opportunity for the person? In what sense is it a burden?
- Are you facing a trade-off between time and project scope? If so, is it more important to meet a deadline or to create a stellar final product? How will delegating help?

Step 3: What—*define the work*

What exactly do you want your direct report to *do*? Be as specific as you can about the activities you'll hand off and the outcomes you want to see. Is the assignment a task, project, or function?

- **Tasks** are discrete activities, like writing a report or planning a meeting. They usually have a clear timeline, work process, and outcome. For example: “I’d like you to administer a customer survey. We need the results (data plus analysis) by next Friday.”

- **Projects** encompass multiple tasks that fulfill a specific objective, like assessing customer needs or developing a new code of conduct. They require more time, resources, and coordination than a single task.

- **Functions** represent an ongoing activity in your unit, like staff training or interfacing with IT. Unlike tasks or projects, functions don’t have a start and end date; they’re a continuous responsibility. That doesn’t necessarily mean they’re more onerous, though. Planning an annual training session involves less work, for example, than a major project or high-profile task.

You should be able to name the overall task, project, or function you’re delegating and list all the associated subtasks and deliverables. You also want to have a clear sense of what skills the work requires. Here is an example:

- **Project:** Develop a new employee code of conduct.

- **Tasks:** Review the current company code and industry standards; hold a focus group or administer a survey; meet with HR and a company lawyer; circulate a draft for input; present final recommendations.

- **Skills:** Research, planning, analytical thinking, written and oral communication, and knowledge of group scheduling and survey apps.

- **Deliverables:** A complete and final draft of the new code of conduct, around forty pages. A presentation on the proposed code to the company leadership.

This is the basic road map you'll give when you talk to your direct report about the assignment. For very experienced employees, you may not need to itemize the work in this much detail. But, in general, it's better to overspecify so you can clear up any misconceptions at the outset.

Step 4: Who—*choose someone to do the work*

Who's the right person for this assignment? There are a lot of factors to balance here, including:

- **Availability.** Who has the availability to take this on? If an employee is too busy to accept a new assignment, how can you help them free up time?

- **Skills.** Who has the cognitive, interpersonal, and technical abilities to do the job well? Who would build important new skills if you gave them this assignment?

- **Motivation.** Who would really embrace this assignment? How does the work align with employees' career strategies or personal goals? Who has relationships—with customers, vendors, with other staff—that this assignment could benefit from?

- **Assistance required.** How much help will the person need from you to be successful? Will you be able to provide that oversight?

- **The team dynamic.** Have you delegated a lot of work to this person in the past? Will this assignment look like favoritism—or like a punishment?

You should be able to explain to your employee and to your own boss why this individual is right for the job: "Luis is well-equipped for this project from a technical standpoint, and it's a great opportunity for him to gain leadership experience."

Step 5: When—*determine the timeline*

When will this work be done? Deadlines are important, but think about time constraints *throughout* the work process. Are you waiting for certain inputs to arrive or for a key collaborator to become available? If the assignment has multiple phases (planning, testing, implementation, or the like), how long will each phase take?

You should be prepared to give your employee a clear deadline and/or timeline for the work.

Step 6: How—*outline the process*

How will your employee do this work so that it meets your standards? You don't need to make a step-by-step plan (that can veer into micromanaging, which we'll deal with later in this chapter). But do think about factors like:

- Will your employee need to collaborate with anyone to complete this assignment?
- How much authority will the person have to make decisions and manage other people?
- What will *your* role be in this process? When will you check in with your direct report, and when should the person seek your approval for any actions?
- What's the budget for this work? What other resources will your staff need (including extra training), and how will you help secure these resources?
- How will you hold your employee accountable to the project's timeline, budget, and quality standards? What metrics will you use to measure these things?

Sharing your delegation plan with your employee

Now that you've drafted the assignment, it's time to bring your employee in to communicate your delegation plan, ask for input, clarify any questions, and agree on a clear timeline and benchmarks for the work.

Your goals here are twofold, requiring you to talk *and* listen carefully. On the one hand, you want to outline your expectations for this assignment, so that your employee clearly understands what you're asking and what success should look like. On the other hand, you want to find out whether your plan as it stands is doable, and make whatever accommodations you can to help your employee do a good job.

But each of these goals draws on different kinds of authority; that's partly what makes delegation so hard. How much are you giving direction, versus soliciting input and consent? If your employee resists the assignment, how will you handle it? Making an assignment and setting expectations is a manager's prerogative, an attribute of your positional power. But in order to make sure the work actually gets done well, you may need to take a more flexible attitude. Remember that leveraging your personal power is all about connecting with others, engaging in active dialogue, and developing the best possible outcome with and through others. By using your personal power when delegating, you're more likely to secure buy-in and encourage enthusiasm with your staff. Avoid using positional power unless absolutely necessary.

The best way to manage these competing goals is to hold the conversation in two distinct phases. Explain to your employee that in the first half, you'll explain the assignment, and then you'll have a chance to discuss and clarify the plan.

Step 1: Explain the assignment

Come prepared with your written delegation plan so that you don't misspeak or skimp on the details. You want to be as clear and precise as you can in this conversation to avoid any miscommunications about what you're asking. Prepare a copy of the assignment so your employee can review the details, take notes, and walk away with a written mandate for action.

This conversation should cover the same basic issues you looked at during your planning phase: why, what, who, when, and how. You may want to linger over details at the end of this list (deadlines, work processes), but your employee still needs a lot of detail at the front end. Think of it as setting context: What's the purpose of this assignment? How does it fit into the bigger picture for your team or for the organization? Why are you engaging them, and what are the benefits? If it's a stretch assignment, they might also worry about being up for the challenge. So emphasize any special training or coaching that you plan to make available.

Step 2: Agree on the plan

Once you've laid out your initial plan, it's time to answer questions, resolve concerns, and incorporate good suggestions from your employee, who might be eager to ask questions. If not, try some of these scripts:

- "What questions do you have about all this? What's not clear?"
- "What ideas do you have about how we could improve this assignment?"
- "Do you have any questions about the scope of your authority here, or about how you'll collaborate with others?"
- "I see us working together in *X* way on this assignment. Do you have any concerns about that?"
- "Is this timeline doable? What problems do you anticipate with the schedule, and what ideas do you have about how to solve them?"
- "I think this is a great opportunity for you to build *X* skill set. How do *you* see this assignment fitting in with your professional goals?"
- "What do you need from me in order to be successful?"

You don't have to accept every suggestion or request, or agree with every idea. But think about what you *can* offer before you say no flat out. For example:

- "I like your ingenuity, but I don't think that will work. Here's why . . ."
- "I don't think we can meet that request, but we could do *X* for you instead. Would that address your concern?"

For all your diplomacy, your employee might not react well to this conversation. Perhaps they feel overworked or exploited; maybe they're scared about taking on more than they can handle and failing publicly. Watch for nonverbal cues that your employee isn't particularly enthusiastic about the opportunity and gently inquire about their concerns. If they have a clearly negative response, ask questions and listen carefully to their answers. Do they have valid concerns? Are you able to address them? Are their arguments making good sense? Should you consider changing the scope of the work, adding a collaborator, or reassigning the project to someone else? If you realize you need to go back to the drawing board, end the conversation graciously: "Thanks for the honest response. You've raised some important issues, and I need to do more research/review this plan before we move forward. I'll follow up with you soon."

If you can't change the assignment or judge that no change is necessary, let your direct report know you understand their feelings. Then reiterate why this work is so important, why you trust them to do it, and what the payoff will be for them down the line. Above all, tell them that you want them to succeed and will do everything you can to help them. Consider language like:

- "I hear that you're anxious/frustrated/overwhelmed, and I'm sorry about that."
- "I *do* believe that you can do this work, and do it well. I wouldn't be asking you if I didn't have confidence in your abilities."
- "It's going to be a difficult couple weeks. But your contributions will matter a lot, because . . . "
- "I know this is an additional burden. I *also* think that it's a real opportunity for you to build your skills/develop your network/advance your career/get recognition outside our group."
- "I want you to ace this assignment, and I will give you all the help I can."
- "Thank you for taking this on. I know you're not happy about it, and I'm grateful for the commitment and character you're showing here."

Step 3: Document your agreement

After the meeting, send an e-mail summarizing the assignment, including deliverables, deadlines, benchmarks, collaborators, quality standards, process requirements, and the date of your next check-in. If you've promised to supply any resources or help, include those details, too. If anyone else needs to know about this assignment—your boss, other staff—you can copy them on this e-mail.

Alternatively, you can ask the employee to document their understanding and send it to you. This can be a good test of their understanding.

Provide support

Your responsibilities don't end when you hand off an assignment. Indeed, your biggest challenge as a delegating manager is to ensure that your direct report doesn't fail. Their good performance matters in itself, and it also colors your reputation throughout the company and with the rest of your team. If something goes wrong, you need to help solve the problem before it's too late.

Monitoring progress (without micromanaging)

To set a rhythm for the work with your employee, hold routine progress updates. This means setting a clear timeline for the work, ideally something you did during your planning phase. For small tasks, it's enough to check in once or twice before the final deadline. For longer, more elaborate projects, consider tying these exchanges to a regular event, like a staff meeting or weekly email status update. Ask your direct report to share a few key pieces of information during each update: where they are with the schedule, what milestones they have achieved, what problems they are facing, and if they have any questions.

Use this window to review your employee's progress and to take whatever steps you need to keep things moving. And document whatever advice or directions you share with them in response to their updates.

Many well-intentioned managers take monitoring their employees' progress too far, however. Avoid hovering over your direct report, second-guessing decisions, and initiating unnecessary or prolonged discussions. Don't pepper your employee with suggestions and questions: "Have you tried this? Any update on that? Don't forget the deadline!" This behavior wastes time and communicates a lack of confidence.

Avoid this kind of micromanaging by thinking of your role here as a monitor and a coach. As a monitor, you'll check in regularly to view the project's vital signs, like benchmarks and quality standards. You'll ask questions like, "What task/phase of the project are you doing right now? Are we on schedule? Can you take me through your recent work?" As a coach, you'll debrief periodically with your employee to troubleshoot and lend your support. You'll ask questions like, "What barriers are you facing right now? How might you overcome those barriers, and what resources or help do you need to do so? What do you need from *me* going forward?" You can even role-play difficult discussions or provide active advice on how your employee can engage others effectively.

Monitoring and coaching work well when your employee has the skills and access to solve whatever problems arise with the plan. But when they lack the skills or influence to solve a problem, you may need to take direct action to remove the roadblock.

Coaching your delegate

Once you have these routines in place, you may need to only offer a few light touches to keep the work on track. When a problem arises, however, you may need to become more involved. Initiate a coaching relationship in order to:

- Help your employee assess the situation
- Encourage them to come up with their own solutions
- Confirm your confidence in their ability to make decisions
- Provide positive reinforcement for the work done so far

For step-by-step advice on how to conduct a coaching session, see the section "Coaching and developing employees" in chapter 10.

Remove roadblocks

If an issue comes up that your delegate can't handle alone—if another manager is refusing to share data, for example, or if there's a companywide systems outage—again, you might need to become more involved. Can you modify the project schedule? Offer more resources? Take on a few subtasks yourself, so the work still comes in on time?

Take this responsibility very seriously as you begin to delegate work. Your role is to eliminate roadblocks that prevent productive work by your team. This may require courage if you have to engage with your peers or boss. Don't shy away from this as one of the responsibilities that comes along with delegation.

Avoid reverse delegation

Sometimes your employees delegate to *you*, either by giving up entirely on a task you've given them or bringing so many problems and decisions back to you that you're effectively carrying the weight of the assignment. Reverse delegation is dangerous; you're not seeing the benefits you identified in your delegation plan, and it can create problem-solving fatigue (a common challenge for new managers in particular). Examine your behavior for three common mistakes that enable reverse delegation:

You fail to provide background information about the task.

You have a wider view of the company than your staff does, and if you've been at the company a long time, you might also have a longer institutional memory. So don't assume your employees know how to navigate company politics—that a certain colleague should always be consulted early on, or that another should only be shown polished work, for example. If the assignment cuts across units, give your employee a briefing on who the relevant players are and what organizational objectives are at stake. And if you're delegating an assignment that someone else has done before—leading a strategic review, for example, or planning a yearly meeting—share the previous year's materials or put them in touch with the person who had their role the last time around.

You take over the wheel as soon as something goes wrong.

At some point, every frustrated manager thinks, "It would be easier if I just did this myself." That might be true in the short term, but in the long run, your effectiveness depends on the competence and adaptability of your team members. They need to climb their own learning curve and work through their own mistakes. When you feel your panic or exasperation growing, push yourself to ask your employee questions before you take action: "What do *you* think the problem is? What options do *you* see before us? What course of action would *you* recommend we take?"

You withhold positive reinforcement.

When your neediest employee comes to you with a basic question about an assignment they were supposed to complete a month ago, you may not see much to praise in their behavior. But if you truly do believe they can do the work (and why would you make the assignment if you didn't?), you'll motivate them more successfully with encouragement than with blame. Expressing frustration and disappointment only undermines their confidence and creates an avoidant mindset: "This work makes me feel bad about myself, so I'll do literally anything *except* finish it." Some well-placed constructive feedback might be necessary. But it's equally necessary to express your appreciation of the work they've done so far and your conviction that they can finish it.

When you delegate with confidence, you craft assignments that your employees can complete successfully. By planning the handoff carefully, you set them up for success.

Recap

- Delegation lowers your stress and lets you focus on high-priority, high-impact tasks that *only* you can do. It also gives employees managerial experience and meets a deep human need for continual growth. Finally, it allows you to maximize your company's resources and improves team performance by deepening trust and boosting self-confidence.
- Making a plan is important so that you don't assign a task to a person with the wrong skill set, for example, or miscommunicate what you want them to do.
- When meeting with your direct reports, talk *and* listen; you want to hear that they understand the assignment, and what questions or concerns they may have.
- Your responsibilities don't end with the handoff. Monitor your direct report's progress in a way that corresponds with the magnitude of the project.
- Keep an eye out for reverse delegation, in which the burden of the work stays with (or returns to) you.
- There is a difference between routine check-ins and micromanaging, which wastes time and communicates a lack of confidence.

Action items

Plan your delegation:

- ❑ Determine what assignments are appropriate to delegate by analyzing your own use of time.
- ❑ Clarify the purpose of this assignment to yourself: How will this arrangement benefit you, your employee, and the company?
- ❑ Define the task, project, or function you're handing over. Itemize the subtasks and deliverables associated with the work.

- ❑ Choose someone for the assignment who has the time, skills, and motivation to do a good job.
- ❑ Specify a timeline for the work: deadlines and any other time constraints.

Schedule a meeting with your team member and:

- ❑ Explain what you're asking, following the "why, what, who, when, how" structure of your delegation plan.
- ❑ Ask for feedback. Incorporate suggestions, and address concerns where you can.
- ❑ Follow up after the meeting with an email that documents your agreement in as much detail as possible.

Support your team member:

- ❑ Monitor progress and have routine project updates for a larger-scale delegation.
- ❑ If your employee is stuck on a particularly difficult problem, set up a coaching session to help them come up with a solution and provide guidance.
- ❑ When your employees come across a problem they simply can't solve on their own, take direct action to remove the roadblock.
- ❑ Give your delegate encouragement during the course of the project.

10.

Giving Effective Feedback

Giving your employees feedback is critical to helping them succeed in their jobs. *Positive* feedback reinforces good work. Praise and coaching advice can create genuine bonds between you and your employees. Those moments when you tell your direct report, "You've done a great job! Congratulations," are powerful connections that build trust and respect for you as a leader.

Corrective feedback urges the recipient to change course or adjust practices that aren't working. Managers—even experienced supervisors—often dread these conversations. Nobody likes having to tell a direct report that their work is subpar, or that they need to adjust their attitude. But when handled well, these conversations produce real change in your employees' behaviors, skills, and outcomes. These interactions create value for yourself (a more productive team), for your organization (better outcomes), and for the employee (pride in their resilience and growth).

Whether you are preparing to give a performance review, looking for ways to turbocharge a star's abilities, or simply need to help a struggling employee get back on track, this chapter helps you deliver feedback in a way that your employee can hear, understand, and implement.

Giving feedback in real time

Your organization probably has several defined mechanisms for giving feedback to employees: coaching sessions, annual reviews, performance interventions, and so on. Each serves an important role. But feedback conversations aren't just a hoop to jump through when these formal appointments roll around. Instead, they should be a continuous practice in your everyday work.

The best time to give feedback, whether positive or constructive, is in the moment. Sharing your real-time reaction to an employee's performance or behavior allows you to acknowledge what you appreciate or offer workers the chance to turn their failures into successes right away. It can be stressful to issue corrective feedback, so you may be tempted to hold off until the behavior occurs again. Don't! Whether you're praising your employees or admonishing them, you will communicate most effectively about the situation when it's fresh in your minds.

Contrast these two approaches to the same situation:

> *You've noticed that a bottleneck is occurring during a production phase overseen by your direct report Gerhard, who normally prides himself on his efficiency.*
>
> Approach 1: *Gerhard's been kind of touchy lately, and you're wary of what he'll say if you point out that he's holding up the rest of the team. Plus, you figure Gerhard usually knows what he's doing—he must have a plan, right? You decide it makes the most sense to wait a few days to see if the problem gets worse before you talk to him about it. The next week, two other employees, Britta and Daniela, request a meeting. They explain that because Gerhard missed a key deadline, the entire production schedule is in jeopardy. And the*

problem may be too late to fix—you may need to ship the product to your client later than promised. Once Britta and Daniela leave, you know you need to talk to Gerhard. This conversation will be much harder than the one you would have had a few days ago.

Approach 2: *After chatting with Gerhard's teammates Britta and Daniela to understand more fully what is going on, you approach Gerhard. You acknowledge the quality of his prior work and ask what he thinks is happening now. As he describes the issue, you discover that he has mistakenly understood that a new step in the production process requires more recordkeeping than it really does. You clarify the requirements, and Gerhard is delighted to stop doing work that had been both time consuming and frustrating. Within a day, the production schedule is back on track.*

In the first scenario, delaying your feedback caused you to miss a key piece of information and put an important revenue stream in jeopardy. Your choice to avoid providing real-time feedback did both the business and Gerhard a disservice. Gerhard will still feel badly about his performance, and you still need to have a tough (now tougher) conversation with him. In the second scenario, your conversation with Gerhard quickly leads to a valuable change. By intervening early, you get tangible results and also help Gerhard to feel good about his work again. Real-time feedback also positions you to check in later for progress.

By making praise and constructive criticism a routine part of your managerial approach, you create countless new opportunities to track improvements, make adjustments, share resources, and offer support. Here are some scripts to try:

- "This work is excellent. Here's what I like about what you've done . . ."
- "I think you can do even better. Here's what I'm thinking of specifically . . ."
- "Can you help me understand your thought process here?"
- "Can I offer you another way of thinking about this?"

Giving difficult feedback

One of the reasons that we avoid giving corrective feedback in the moment is that it can be unpleasant to deliver criticism. Many managers worry that:

- Criticism will set off a heightened emotional reaction, like anger or crying, or the person will shut down and fail to engage in the conversation.
- The problem they need to address touches too closely on the employee's identity and will challenge this person's sense of self as a competent professional.
- They may have to tell an employee that their paycheck or job security is at stake.

To mitigate these factors, follow these steps:

Step 1: Understand the situation objectively

INSEAD professor Jean-François Manzoni suggests you begin by examining why you need to give feedback in the first place. Too often, he says, we draw strong conclusions about a situation without entertaining alternatives. For example, if we suspect that one person's difficult personality is causing a team conflict, we rarely look into secondary theories, such as whether the employees in question have clashing work styles.

We also tend to see the stakes of our feedback in win-lose terms. Because we have a hardened preconception of what the source of the problem is, we think we know the only solution. And if a feedback interaction ends without the employee accepting that solution, it must be a failure.

Once you're aware of these biases, you can correct for them. Start by analyzing what you actually know about the situation:

- What have you observed firsthand? What biases might be coloring your memory?
- What have other people told you? What are their biases?

- What other cues are you interpreting—tone, body language, a sequence of events? How much weight should you give these interpretations?
- What *don't* you know? What *didn't* you witness? Whose perspective *haven't* you heard?
- What are other possible explanations for the employee's actions and behaviors?

In general, the fewer conclusions you draw from these facts, the better. Instead, identify questions you want to ask your employee.

Step 2: Plan the conversation

Write down your key points before you go into the meeting—questions raised in step 1, or any other information you want to convey, like the behavior that needs to change or the goal of the change. That way you'll know what you want to say as you begin the conversation. These notes can also help you reorient yourself in the middle of the meeting if you get distracted.

Rehearse ahead of time if you can, by yourself or with a colleague. Role-playing can help you see the situation from your direct report's perspective and figure out what approach will work best.

Also let your employee know ahead of time what you'll be discussing, so they don't feel blindsided: "I'd like to speak to you tomorrow about the efficiency of the production process lately."

Step 3: Lead the meeting

When the meeting begins, it's generally best to jump into the negative feedback right away. Sometimes managers try to ease into an unpleasant conversation by asking leading questions ("Are you happy with your performance right now?"), but if your employee doesn't know how to play along, or chooses not to, you'll both feel frustrated. Another common tactic to diffuse the awkwardness is the feedback sandwich: open with praise, move to criticism, close with praise. But if you don't have any genuine accolades to offer, your employee will see this for the trick it is. Instead, start by simply naming the topic you want to discuss: "I'd like to talk about your production output and the bottlenecks that have been coming up."

Talk about the employee's behavior, not motivations.

Often if an employee's productivity slows down, we're more likely to blame them for being lazy than to investigate other factors, like a process change. That's because, according to Manzoni, "most people tend to overestimate the effect of a person's stable characteristics . . . and underestimate the impact of the specific conditions under which that person is operating." But often we're wrong. And even when we're not, analyzing personal traits tends to alienate your employee.

When you give feedback, focus instead on behaviors and skills. Avoid making global statements ("You're *X* kind of person") or speaking in absolutes ("You always do *Y*"). Instead, use language like:

"I'm concerned about this *behavior*."

"When you *did* this . . ."

"When you *said* that . . ."

"As a *result* of your actions . . ."

"The *impact* of this behavior on your coworkers/the company/ me is . . ."

"The *outcome* I want to address is . . ."

Elicit the employee's point of view.

The preparation that you did about your biases and your knowledge of the situation allows you to approach your employee with questions instead of an accusation, Manzoni says. "I don't know if you're aware of this—or if it's true or not—but I've heard that we're behind where we want to be with production. What do you think?"

Asking for your employee's take on a problem means you might learn something important—perhaps they are involved in an interpersonal conflict in the office that you weren't aware of, or maybe they're dealing with a technical problem that's more complex than you realized—or, as in Gerhard's case in the example, they may have some misconceptions about what is expected.

Second, by giving the employee the opportunity to explain what's going on, you're communicating that you see them as a person. Your employee probably feels very vulnerable in these moments, and they need to believe that you want to treat them fairly and care about how they perceive the situation.

Consider phrases such as:

> "What's your view on this issue?"
>
> "How does what I've said track with your experience?"
>
> "Have I left out anything important?"
>
> "I hear what you're saying."
>
> "That's an important perspective."
>
> "You and I are on the same page here."
>
> "Thanks for sharing this information with me."

Don't escalate.

If your employee challenges you by contesting your facts or pushing back against your interpretation, take a deep breath before you respond. Too often, managers dig in their heels at these moments because they think their authority is being tested. In fact, you'll gain more personal power by being honest, fair, and emotionally generous in a trying situation. Try to locate specific points of agreement and then also disagreement, and keep asking questions about them:

> "Can you help me understand this point more clearly?"
>
> "It sounds like you're hearing me say *X*. I must not be communicating very clearly, because that's not what I want to say to you. My point is *Y*."

"We're on the same page about *X*, but I think there's a gap in how we're thinking about *Y*. I think that gap is coming from this . . . What do you think?"

Step 4: Look ahead

As with coaching and performance reviews, move the conversation toward an agreement about next steps: "So you'll use the more streamlined approach to the production recordkeeping going forward." If you can't reach an agreement or if the conversation gets too heated, it's OK to press pause: "Let's stop here for now. I think we both need some time to process everything we've talked about. We can meet again in a week." With a little time, you both might calm down enough to reach an accord or it can give you time to solicit others' input.

Coaching and developing employees

Coaching is a proactive dialogue between you and your team members intended to foster high performance and long-term development. Coaching is less transactional than feedback, which tends to focus on specific situations and outcomes. Ed Batista, an executive coach and instructor at the Stanford Graduate School of Business, argues that coaching as a practice is broadly applicable and that managers at all levels can benefit from working with their direct reports in this way.

Batista describes coaching as the practice of "asking questions that help people discover the answers that are right for them." Asking questions instead of offering solutions pushes your employees to develop critical thinking skills and the confidence to act on their own. It also puts the onus on them to solve problems and own the results. Ultimately, your aim is to help employees become more adaptive and self-sufficient.

Coaching requires time, effort, and an emotional openness from *both* participants; it's a true partnership. You can compel a direct report to attend a meeting about their performance, but you can't make them think critically about their work, try new techniques, or persevere through failure. Employees who aren't willing to do these things aren't good candidates for coaching. But when you and your employee approach this relationship with enthusiasm and mutual respect, it's one of the powerful strategies you have for developing talent.

When to coach

Most managers approach coaching as a semiformal arrangement, with regular meetings and discussions, sometimes involving goals, action items and follow-ups. That said, you can use coaching strategies in your daily interactions—when a direct report hails you in the hallway with a problem, for example. To determine if you're in a situation where coaching is likely to work, look for these cues:

- Your employee genuinely wants to improve their performance.
- They're frustrated or bored because they're not working from their strengths.
- They're professionally stymied by personal obstacles, like a fear of public speaking.
- They've formulated specific professional goals and need help reaching them.
- They're good at their job, but don't know how to manage themselves.

If you think coaching could help a member of your team, talk to them about what you'd like to do. Now is the time to explain how it will work: "I'd like to work with you as a coach to help you address *X* problem/work on *X* behaviors/develop *X* competency. If you agree, we'll meet periodically to do goal setting and problem solving together around this issue. My role here would be to support your growth, not to give you tactical direction. Think of it as a dedicated half hour when I can serve as a sounding board and a resource. Is this something you could commit to?" If your employee agrees, schedule your first coaching session.

How to hold a coaching session

Coaching sessions are a special kind of conversation, says executive coach Amy Jen Su. Compared with a performance review or a one-on-one meeting, they take the broadest view, looking at past performance, current projects, and future development.

Step 1: Prepare for the meeting.

Coaching sessions require forethought and planning on your part or else your direct report won't put in the work either. Identify specific performance issues you'd like to address, skill gaps you'd like to fill, or a new role you're preparing your employee for. How are *your* aims likely to tie in with theirs?

Step 2: Begin by inviting your employees to take the lead.

Your employee brings their own agenda to the table, so ask them about it. "What do *you* want to achieve during these sessions?" "What do you want to make sure we get to?" The kind of help you offer will depend on the needs they express, so listen for these three categories:

- **Long-term development.** They want to build new skills or work toward major career goals.
- **Debriefing an event or project.** They want to learn from recent experience and come up with strategies for handling similar situations in the future.
- **Short-term problem solving.** They have an imminent issue and need an action plan right now.

As you listen, look for links between their goals and yours. What connection exists between their long-term career strategy and the performance issue you want to fix? How can you address a skill gap during a problem-solving session? By finding commonalities, you can shape the purpose of these sessions in concert with your employee.

Step 3: Build a shared understanding of the issues.

At this stage, build a shared narrative with your employees about what is and isn't working in their current situation. "Your employee very likely still knows more about it than you do," says Jen Su, and certainly they know more about their point of view. Bring all of that information out into the open by asking questions, such as:

- Long-term development

  "What's your comfort level in this area? How do you *want* to feel about it?"

  "How have you performed in the past? What should success look like?"

  "How do you prepare for this now? How could you prepare differently?"

- Debrief on an event or project

  "How did things go? In an ideal world, what would have happened?"

  "How would you describe your impact? What worked well? What didn't?"

  "How would you prepare or handle this differently for this next time?"

- Short-term problem solving

  "Tell me more about the situation, your tasks and deadlines."

  "Which of these are tied to our group's highest priorities?

  "What courses of action are available to you? How feasible are they?"

Use active listening techniques and ask open-ended questions. Keep a lid on your reactions, if you can; your employee will feel safer sharing their vulnerabilities if you maintain a neutral, sympathetic demeanor, and let them talk without interruption.

Step 4: Reframe the issue.

Once your employee has laid out their point of view, it's time to start working on solutions and next steps together. Instead of offering advice ("Try *X*. Here's how *I* do it . . . "), help them think more critically about the assumptions and choices that are already driving their behavior. You can do this by helping them see themes in what they've said, and by offering competing lenses through which they can see the issue at hand. Consider language like:

"You seem worried about . . ." or "It sounds like your main concern is . . ."

"I notice you've used this same phrase a couple times in this conversation. Why is that important to you?"

"I see a pattern in how you deal with ___ issue. What's going on there?"

"It sounds to me like your current outlook emphasizes *X*, but doesn't allow much room for *Y*. How could that be holding you back?"

"Have you seen someone else be successful with this issue in the past? How did they approach it?"

"What if you looked at it from this angle/tried this tactic? How would that play out?"

Step 5: Close with an action plan.

End with a clear action plan for your employees, something that will help them make meaningful progress and hold them accountable going forward. Ask them to articulate their main takeaways orally, or write up their to-do list in an email after the session. Your role in this stage is to ensure that the goals are realistic, help them prioritize tasks, highlight obstacles and brainstorm solutions, and provide additional support as needed.

Step 6: Follow up.

After the session ends, check up on your direct reports to make sure that they continue to improve. Schedule more coaching sessions, if they're needed. And touch base casually to learn what's working and what isn't, modify the action plan, secure additional resources, and give feedback—whether to praise or to improve. Even if you are pressed for time, still put these check-ins on your calendar. A one-line email or quick word of encouragement can go a long way toward sustaining your employees' motivation as they grow.

Performance reviews

While coaching requires more planning than a casual, one-off feedback conversation, performance reviews generally occur annually. As with coaching sessions, you'll use them to discuss goals, provide feedback, and correct performance problems. Unlike coaching, these appraisals directly affect salary decisions and promotions. That can make them time consuming and stressful for manager and employee alike.

If approached with the right frame of mind, they're well worth the effort. You don't often have the chance to sit down with your people, face to face, and say: "Here's where you stand." "This is what I need from you." "Thank you for your outstanding work." During these meetings, you can address all the critical issues that get lost in the daily grind.

Your formal feedback will give your direct report the opportunity for growth. Moreover, a yearly review offers them some protection when they're struggling with performance issues. If you address their problems head on in regular, formal meetings, they won't be blindsided by bad news when it's too late to do anything about it.

Performance reviews are also valuable to your organization. The information you collect and codify will help the company make valid decisions about pay and developing talent. And when it comes to difficult employees, performance reviews protect your organization again lawsuits by employees who have been fired, demoted, or denied a merit increase.

There's no one right way to conduct a performance review: every organization has its procedures, and each situation presents a different set of challenges. Here is a set of general steps:

Step 1: Prepare your employee

It's important to involve your employees in every stage of the process, so that their point of view is incorporated. Start by asking them to complete a self-appraisal. In many companies, HR provides a checklist for this purpose, with the goals, behaviors, and functions associated with each employee's role. If you're making your own list, include questions like:

- How well do you feel you've achieved your professional goals?
- What accomplishments are you proudest of? What contributed to your success?
- Which goals are you currently struggling with? What's holding back your progress?

Whether you're using a template from HR or making your own, make sure that the performance goals you reference are items that you've already shared with the employee at their last review or when they were hired. You can use this list to prepare your own appraisal, too. Look through the notes you've collected about each person's performance—projects they've worked on, feedback you've given them, any complaints or commendations from their colleagues. If possible, solicit feedback from others in the company who have worked with your direct report.

Dick Grote, who has created performance management systems for hundreds of the world's biggest organizations, recommends giving your employees a copy of your appraisal an hour or so before your review meeting starts. "When people read someone's assessment of them, they are going to have all sorts of churning emotions," he notes. "Let them have that on their own time, and give them a chance to think about it."

Step 2: Open with a tone of partnership

Your employee may have an emotional response to reading your review, so as your meeting begins, do what you can to put them at ease as you settle in; don't let them feel as if they're in the prisoner's dock, about to receive judgment. Next, invite your employee to share their self-appraisal: "I'd like to start by asking you to talk a little about how you feel you're doing." Listen carefully and don't interrupt. This phase of a performance review, like a coaching session, will help you understand your direct report's point of view and tailor your remarks later in the conversation.

Step 3: Share your appraisal

Traditionally, performance reviews are treated as a place to focus on what's *not* working with a direct report. But exclusively or dominantly focusing on the negative can be hugely discouraging. Be clear in highlighting the strengths you appreciate about employees. If they highlighted the same area of strength in their self-assessment, reinforce their perception. If they didn't, share why you value a particular talent or skill.

Carefully choose the areas of development that are most important to discuss in the performance review. Use a conversational tone to review the expectation, the gap, and the opportunity to demonstrate improvement. As with all corrective feedback, don't be vague ("You're not a team player") or make it about your feelings ("I'm so disappointed"). Instead, talk about specific behaviors: "When you do *X*, it is causing a problem for the team" or "You're not meeting *Y* performance target." Being clear and succinct in these moments is actually the most respectful thing you can do: you're treating your employee like a mature adult and giving them the information they need to do better.

Step 4: Probe for the root cause of performance gaps

Once you've given positive or corrective feedback, encourage your employee to reflect their perceptions. Pay close attention to how they respond by:

- **Listening actively.** Concentrate on your employees' message and its implications rather than on your response. In particular, listen to the elements of the critique that they've honed in on, and pay attention to the images and metaphors they use. If you don't understand something, ask.

- **Noticing nonverbal cues.** Observe your employee's body language and tone. Do their voice and facial expressions match what they're saying? Comment on what you see and ask them to tell you more about it: "Bill, you seem angry. Did something I say seem unfair to you? Tell me about it."
- **Paraphrasing what your employee says.** By restating a response in different words, you show them that you understand their point. If anything is unclear, ask more questions until you are on the same page.

Step 5: Create a new performance plan

Give your employee the first opportunity to develop a plan to close any gaps between their current and required performance: "What would you propose?" They'll be more committed to a solution they've authored and more explicitly responsible for carrying it out. As with coaching, you can challenge questionable assumptions or offer ideas to strengthen the plan. In some cases, you'll need to be very directive. For staff with major performance gaps, the product of this conversation will be part of their record and should include:

- Specific goals
- A timeline
- Action steps
- Expected outcomes
- Required trainings or resources

You don't need to limit this conversation to strengths and problem areas. Since an entire year may have passed since their last performance review, take this opportunity to reexamine their overall performance goals, too. Do they still make sense—for the individual team member, for your unit, and for the organization as a whole?

Step 6: Get it on the record

Document whatever agreements you make and include:

- The date
- Key points from your employee's self-appraisal
- Key points from your appraisal
- A summary of the performance plan
- Agreed-on next steps
- Performance goals for the coming year

Your company will likely require you to provide copies of this record (as well as the review itself) to your direct report and HR. Keep a version in your own files, too. In most cases, you and your employee will both have to sign the review, and your employee has a legal right to append their own comments.

Step 7: Follow up

After your annual performance review discussions, make note of the follow-up that's required with each of your team members. For high performers, it might include coaching discussions to prepare them for new responsibilities. Employees who are struggling should be monitored carefully around the performance plan you jointly developed. Consider these options for your follow-up:

- Planning monthly or quarterly meetings to check progress
- Checking in virtually on a more frequent basis—for example, with weekly email updates or a digital performance log
- Initiating a coaching relationship

- Helping them connect with a mentor
- Auditing their needs for more resources or training

Giving feedback during a performance review is more formal and therefore requires steps, like more elaborate documentation and preparation. But in delivering your review, the same principles apply as in the informal feedback you supply more frequently: listen actively and maintain a tone of partnership.

Both corrective and positive feedback, given well, can solve imminent problems and also help your employees grow in their careers. By giving feedback in a way that your employees can hear and act on, you'll build their trust in you as a guide and advocate, and provide value for your organization as well.

Recap

- Giving your team members feedback is critical to helping them succeed in their jobs.
- *Positive* feedback reinforces good work. *Corrective* feedback urges the recipient to change course or adjust practices that aren't working.
- Sharing feedback in real time gives you and your employee the best chance to resolve the issue in question.
- Following a process in which you ask questions and have an open view of the outcome of your feedback will make it more effective and easier for your colleague to hear.
- *Coaching* is a proactive dialogue between you and your team members intended to foster high performance and long-term development.
- Though coaching is not just for your stars, not all situations are right for coaching.

- Similar principles hold for delivering performance reviews as for other forms of feedback, though performance reviews also call for more-formal documentation.

Action items

When giving feedback:

- ❑ Seek an objective understanding of the situation you want to address by examining your own biases and assumptions.
- ❑ Plan what you want to say in the conversation and rehearse with a colleague if you can. Let your employees know ahead of time what the topic of your meeting is, so they don't feel blindsided.
- ❑ During the meeting, talk about behaviors, rather than motivations.
- ❑ Elicit your employee's perspective on the issue and resist the urge to escalate the interaction if you feel challenged; ask more questions.
- ❑ Close the meeting by looking ahead: What agreement can you make about next steps and future expectations?

When coaching:

- ❑ Check the list of cues given earlier to determine if the situation you are facing now is right for coaching.
- ❑ Prepare for a coaching session by thinking through your own goals for the coaching relationship.
- ❑ Open the meeting by asking your employee to take the lead. Listen to what's currently on *their* mind, and look for links between their goals and yours. Use that common ground to define a shared goal for your partnership.
- ❑ Build a shared understanding of the issue you're working on by asking open-ended questions. Resist the urge to correct or override the employee's point of view.

- ❑ Reframe the issue by helping them see themes in what they've told you and offering new lenses on the problem.
- ❑ Close with a concrete action plan for what they'll do next. Let them take the lead here, but offer advice about what's realistic.
- ❑ Follow up afterward with a formal coaching session or in casual conversation.

When conducting a performance review:

- ❑ Ask your employee to conduct a self-appraisal. Use this, along with other records of performance, to create your own comprehensive review of their work.
- ❑ Open the meeting with a tone of partnership by asking your employee to share a self-appraisal. Maintain a professional, friendly tone throughout.
- ❑ Next, go over your assessment of their performance. Balance positive and constructive feedback, described in straightforward language.
- ❑ Probe for the root cause of a performance gap by asking for their perspective on a problem. Continue to discuss until you both understand the underlying cause.
- ❑ Invite your employee to take the lead in creating a new performance plan with specific goals and a timeline. Get plans on record and distribute appropriately.
- ❑ Identify your own follow-up items, including regular check-ins, coaching sessions, or other support as needed.

11.

Developing Talent

The world is constantly changing, and your organization along with it. Your team—the company's human capital—drives that change and shapes your company's future. Your role as a manager is to develop talent that meets the needs of your business. It is fundamentally future-oriented, ensuring you can deliver exceptional performance both today and tomorrow. Whereas feedback aims to improve performance now, talent development expands your employees' capacities for the future.

The best managers know how to balance the needs of the organization with the interests of its employees. As you work with your employees to identify new skills, new experiences, and new responsibilities of interest, you're helping them find work that's fulfilling. As their manager, you must also look for the resonances between their desires and your company's needs. In this chapter, you'll learn about the benefits of employee development, as well as how to spot those opportunities and help your employees take advantage of them.

Employee development as a priority

One of the most important and rewarding responsibilities you have as a manager is to develop the capabilities of your direct reports. That means helping them:

- Discover their passion and purpose
- Identify their work values
- Understand the organization's priorities and politics
- Improve their skills
- Expand their competencies
- Challenge themselves with new experiences
- Acquire mentors and build their professional network
- Discover how to manage others

You've already thought about how to do many of these things for yourself and sought to negotiate opportunities for growth with your own boss (see chapter 8, "Self-Development"). You asked yourself, "How does my work fit into the vision I have for my life and my career purpose?" Now you're looking at the issue through the eyes of your employees and your motivation is a little different: you want to help others grow and align to their greater purpose, but with a focus on how that growth will intersect with the business goals of your unit.

The company benefits greatly from your investments in talent development. Many managers assume that the personal happiness of their employees conflicts with the needs of the business, and that they must choose between the two. But that's a mistake. Employee development is one of your core responsibilities for a reason: It directly serves your business's interests. By encouraging your direct reports to think strategically about their career and helping them become more capable and content, you're creating tangible value for your organization.

Developing your employees also benefits you. If you can improve your team's performance and move promising players to the next level, you'll enhance your reputation with upper-level management. What's more, your staff's expanding networks can enrich your own professional connections. New experiences bring them into contact with people you might be glad to know. And you'll refresh your existing network, too, as they develop new relationships with *your* old colleagues, like other managers in your company. It is incredibly rewarding to invest time and energy to develop the talents of others in the organization.

Of course, your employees are the most obvious beneficiaries here. The payoff is clear with star performers, who will rise to higher and higher levels of responsibility with your help. But it's just as important to spend time with all of your employees. Even people with more modest professional goals will perform better in their current role if they feel that you respect and support their growth. Nearly all employees have a basic human need to keep learning. Frederick Herzberg, a psychologist who studied employees' motivation, argued that money is a less powerful motivator than opportunities to learn, advance in their responsibilities, and be recognized for their achievements. Employee development doesn't need to be about facilitating your employees' meteoric rise to the top; it's more about helping them achieve this fundamental satisfaction in their everyday work and reach their highest potential, whatever that might be.

Creating career strategies with your staff

Effective managers help employees discover what they *really* want out of their work and how they can use their present situation as a springboard to reach those goals. That means talking to your direct reports about their hopes and dreams, but also engaging in some practical brainstorming about where they can find opportunities for growth in your organization and how their present role could be reengineered for the better.

In the past, when many companies had more defined career paths for advancement, this conversation would have gone a little differently. Most companies had a career ladder of some form, a logical series of stages that moved a talented and promotable employee through progressively more challenging and responsible positions. Managers propelled their employees to the next rung when the manager and HR colleagues judged them ready. The path for growth was mostly unidirectional: up, in whatever stream of the business they'd already landed in.

Today, the map for each employee's development is more complicated. You can move up, but also *over* through a lateral career move—for example, from customer service representative to user-experience (UX) researcher. And because many companies have adopted flexible organizational structures, employees can also grow in the same position by reinventing their responsibilities.

All this means that career advancement requires more initiative and more imagination than ever before, from employee and manager alike. That's great, because it gives you and your employee the opportunity to craft a strategy that's responsive to the company and the individual's needs, something you couldn't do when organizational structures were more rigid.

Take the example of the customer service rep who wants to transition to UX. That's a difficult jump to make if each business division has a strictly regimented pecking order ("UX researchers must have at least three years' experience as a UX research assistant"). But if you and your counterpart in the other unit can work together to bring a bright rep over to UX quarter-time, both departments will benefit tremendously. The UX team can use their direct line into customer service to identify design problems, and customer service can use the employee's new expertise to improve internal tools, from rewriting agendas to customizing software settings, as well as customer-facing scripts and services. Similar opportunities to this one abound.

Step 1: Talk to your direct reports

Start with your employees. To support their growth, you need to understand their aspirations and their current state of development. The more you know about the people who work for you, the more you'll be able to motivate them, coach them, and help them grow. The coaching sessions,

Employee development interview

To help your direct reports create and implement a career strategy, sit down with them to learn how they see their current situation and future path. This is an intimate conversation, so prepare them ahead by letting them know what you'd like to discuss, and share any questions you'd like them to give special thought to. Use these questions from psychiatrist Edward Hallowell, who has studied the brain science of high performance:

INTERESTS AND SKILLS

Learn about what kind of work they enjoy and what direction they'd like to keep growing in by asking the following questions:

- "What are you best at doing? What do you most like to do?"
- "What do you wish you were better at? What talents do you have that you haven't developed?"
- "What skills are you most proud of? What do others say are your greatest strengths? What have you gotten better at?"
- "What are you just not getting better at, no matter how hard you try? What do you most dislike doing? The lack of which skills most gets in your way?"
- "Can you think of ways to incorporate more of what you do best and what you most enjoy into your job?"
- "Can you think of ways to build on your strengths and accomplishments to date in your current role?"
- "Everyone has weaknesses and dislikes. How do you think you can continue to compensate for yours? How would your work have to evolve to accommodate them?"

ORGANIZATIONAL FIT

Understand what kind of environment they need to thrive by asking:

- "What sorts of people do you work best and worst with? Do you hate to work with highly organized, analytic people, or do you love it? Do creative types drive you crazy, or do you work well with them?"
- "What sort of organizational culture brings out the best in you? What tweaks would make this organization a better fit? What aspects trouble you the most?"

WORK VALUES

Find out what they think a good career looks like by asking:

- "What was the most important work-related lesson you learned from your parents?"
- "What lesson did the best boss you ever had teach you about yourself?"
- "What one lesson about managing a career would you pass along to the next generation? How would you apply that lesson to yourself right now?"
- "What are you most proud of in your work life? What regrets do you have about how you have run your career? Could you make any changes based on those regrets?"

performance reviews, and feedback meetings discussed in chapter 10, "Giving Effective Feedback," provide many opportunities to gain this understanding. If you haven't yet discussed these bigger-picture issues with them yet, look at the box "Employee development interview" for possible scripts.

Step 2: Suggest training opportunities

Close out the conversation by suggesting a few next steps for them:

- "In an ideal world, what would your work-life balance look like? Looking forward over the next six months, one year, and five years, how do you see yourself achieving that balance?"
- "What were you doing when you were happiest in your work life? How could you incorporate that into what you're doing now?"

VISION OF THE FUTURE

Discover what ambitions they already have for their development by asking:

- "What are your most cherished hopes for the future, workwise? What stands in the way of realizing those hopes?"
- "What are your short-term and long-term professional goals?"
- "Do you have other, big-picture personal development goals that dovetail with your professional ambitions? How do these personal and professional goals relate to each other?"
- "How could we better structure your current role to add value to the organization? Are there other opportunities in the company you'd like to explore?"

Source: Adapted from Edward Hallowell, *Shine: Using Brain Science to Get the Best from Your People*. Boston: Harvard Business Review Press, 2011.

- **Meet with HR** about formal skill trainings, a mentorship program, or other opportunities for growth. Can you connect them to someone you already have a relationship with?
- **Find informal training opportunities.** Encourage them to search for online courses, local conferences or seminars, or books that could help them develop specific skills.

- **Schedule informational interviews** with other people in the company. Can you introduce them to any colleagues who might be able to act as a mentor or offer a learning opportunity, like a temporary or part-time assignment?
- **Pitch you on a job redesign** that would solve a specific problem for your unit or improve its performance, while creating new growth opportunities for them. Can you identify your top problems for them, or share other information about the organizational priorities that are driving your business strategy right now?

Step 3: Refresh responsibilities

While your employees are following up on your initial discussion, there are a few things you can do to make their current role align better with the trajectory they're charting:

- Redefine their job so that they do more work they'll enjoy and learn from.
- Find a mentor for them within your team who can teach them the skills they want to know.
- Delegate stretch assignments that will help them grow, or expose them to different parts of the company.
- Make them the point person on your team for dealing with another business unit that's relevant to their interests.
- Negotiate temporary or part-time assignments for them with colleagues in other units.
- Involve them in your silo-busting efforts (see chapter 5, "Becoming a Person of Influence") to coordinate with other parts of the organization.

Some of these options will require your employees to spend time away from your team, working in other parts of the company with other managers. Don't look at this as losing their time. A well-conceived assignment will benefit your group, too. If, down the line, you do end up grooming a particular employee for a promotion within your unit, the experience in a different area will serve them well. And if they ultimately choose to move into another role outside the team, you'll benefit from having a colleague who understands and values what your staff does.

Developing high-potential talent

High performers, who typically make up about 5 to 10 percent of your team, have unique needs. These employees exhibit strong performance and show great potential to do even more for the organization. This group requires a commitment from you to develop and promote their talent in the organization.

To identify your high performers, look for the team members who:

- Exceed your standards on multiple measures
- Act on constructive feedback in order to improve performance
- Show potential to perform at a higher level within the next year or two
- Make key contributions to the team
- Work hard under pressure and pick up slack from others
- Act as a positive role model for others

High performers typically place a high value on their own development and see it as a sign that your company is a good place to build a career. When you meet star employees for development interviews, start by offering specific, detailed praise about their work; they may not know how good it is or what kinds of effort are most valuable to you and the rest of the team.

Come prepared to talk about specific opportunities you think they might benefit from, for example, skill training through HR or a temporary assignment with another team. (Your preparation for this meeting might include touching base with your own boss to talk about how employees' development could meet larger needs in the unit, or coincide with your own plans for advancement.) Then follow up within the company in a timely way to make sure that these resources and opportunities come through. Even if everything doesn't pan out, you want to be able to tell high achievers that you're doing everything you can for them. Your advocacy as their boss is important to them.

In addition to promoting your direct reports' career goals, you should also make sure you—and they—understand the cost of what it takes them to achieve those great results. If their work habits aren't sustainable, they risk burning out and maybe quitting your organization altogether. So check in frequently to make sure work isn't disrupting important life functions like health, family, and leisure. Ultimately your employees' work-life balance is up to them: if they choose to forgo their hobbies and their kids' sports games in the name of work, you can't stop them. But you can make sure that you're communicating clear expectations and empowering them to work well. Make a habit of asking, "How can I continue to support you?" and "What can we do as an organization to get better at supporting your great work?"

High performers put themselves under a lot of pressure, but there are a few things you can do to help them grow in a healthy way:

Set boundaries with compassion.

When your employee interrupts you in front of your boss to show off their expertise, you might feel angry. But expressing these negative feelings to a star player may cause a backlash. Instead of saying "That was out of line!" wait until your feelings have calmed and then try a compassionate question that pushes them to reflect on their own motives:

"Your interjection earlier surprised me. What were you hoping to accomplish there? What do you think the effect was?"

They'll probably say something like, "I wanted to make a point I thought you were missing."

Don't argue. Instead, probe their response gently: "I thought I had explained to you my plan for how to approach this meeting. What made you think I wasn't going to carry it off?" Then state your expectations clearly: "Here's how I'd like to handle that next time." Help them stay true to their motivation to present themselves in the best possible light and encourage them to do so without stepping on or around anyone else.

Praise personally, praise often.

High performers often second-guess praise, even when they need it badly. So it's important to make your accolades as specific as you can, tailored to their own self-perceptions. For example, if they pride themselves on being a good writer, don't tell them the graphics in the presentation were top-notch. Instead, point to writing details: "Your phrasing on the closing slide was very powerful. We should consider incorporating that language into our team's vocabulary." Keep your comments authentic by avoiding exaggeration or clichés.

You may find the constant pressure to produce praise exhausting. That's only natural; it *is* exhausting. But remember that however unimportant these compliments seem to you, they're fulfilling a genuinely vital psychological need in your employees. You can help them by digging deep in yourself to share the real gratitude and admiration you feel for their exceptional performance.

Stretch assignments

Stretch assignments give employees an opportunity to assume new responsibilities that will challenge current competencies and provide an opportunity for growth. This might be a temporary or part-time assignment covering for a coworker on leave or running a short-term project. Or perhaps you're delegating an important leadership function, like acting as a liaison with another department. The ultimate stretch assignment, of course, is a full-time promotion to another role in your unit or elsewhere in the company.

Whatever the particulars, these assignments are a calculated risk on everyone's part: the company, your employee, and you. If your employee succeeds, the company benefits from their talent, and they get an impressive new responsibility. You get the satisfaction of seeing your direct report shine, a reputational refraction of their success, and (depending on the assignment) the use of their talents in a brand-new way. If they fail, though, everyone feels the downside. Your company might incur losses in productivity or profit; your employee, deeply demoralized, may take a big step back in their career path; and you must manage the fallout to your unit *and* your good name.

All this means that you'd better choose carefully, says Claudio Fernández-Aráoz, a senior adviser at the global executive search firm Egon Zehnder. Whether you're recommending your employee for a position elsewhere in the company or reassigning them on your own team, there are a few questions you should ask yourself:

Do they really have what it takes?

Their intelligence, creativity, and work ethic are probably well known to you. But other intangibles, more difficult to evaluate, matter just as much. Are they motivated by a desire to help others succeed or chiefly by a selfish ambition? Do they have the right leadership assets—resilience, sociability, and the willingness to learn? Are they really prepared to accept the personal costs of a more strenuous position?

Is it the right opportunity?

Fernández-Aráoz argues that "the sweet spot of development for high achievers is when you have a 50–70% chance of success." You're looking for an assignment that the employee has a real shot of completing, but where they will genuinely have to fight for their success. As you evaluate the match, don't limit yourself to considerations of skill and experience. What about the cultural fit? Will your direct report have any social capital to draw on in this posting? Review, too, the consequences for your company (and yourself) if this assignment doesn't pan out. How much damage could a failure inflict? Would you be able to recover?

Can you make it happen?

Securing a stretch assignment can be difficult, especially if you need to get senior management or executive approval. Start by choosing the right sponsor—someone with the right mix of power and credibility who can cosign your recommendation. When you make the pitch, don't overjustify the candidate's background. Instead, focus on the core competencies that you think make them a good fit for the role. Be prepared to speak in detail about your own experience managing them and present the risks honestly, so that nothing comes out later to make a liar of you. Finally, have a plan for how your unit will accommodate this change. Who will perform your employee's current responsibilities? If the assignment will split their time, how will you help them manage their time?

Over the course of your career, some of these assignments will backfire. As long as everyone is prepared for that possibility and understands the risks, that's OK.

Developing talent is incredibly rewarding for managers. It isn't easy to find the time required to do this well. But you need to make time. The work you put into the manager-employee relationship, from delegating assignments to giving effective feedback and coaching, all positions you for success with the longer-term responsibility of talent development. Your company is counting on you to ensure the future needs of the business will be met. When you're pressed for time and you feel as if your own performance is under a microscope, you may shy away from making the necessary investments in your people's development. Challenge yourself here and not only will your employees benefit, you and your organization will, too.

In part four, "Managing Teams," you'll learn how to channel these individual abilities into a coherent and creative team.

Recap

- One of the most important and rewarding responsibilities you have as a manager is to develop the capabilities of your direct reports.
- Your organization also benefits greatly from your investments in talent development. Help others grow with a focus on how that growth will intersect with the business goals of your unit.
- Today's world of lateral career moves means you and your employees can be creative about crafting career strategies that are responsive to their—and the company's—needs.
- High performers, who typically make up 5 to 10 percent of your team, place a high value on their own development and therefore have a unique set of development needs and risks.
- Stretch assignments are a calculated risk on everyone's part—the company, your employees—and you. But they will also give your employees new responsibilities and the opportunity for growth.

Action items

- ❑ Consider all of the actions you've taken in the past year to further employee development on your team—coaching, stretch assignments, and so on. Which of these activities are paying off right now? What more can you do?

To create a career strategy with one of your direct reports:

- ❑ Talk to your direct report about their interests and skills, organizational fit, work values, and their vision of the future; conduct an Employee Development Interview (see questionnaire in the box given earlier).
- ❑ Based on their response, suggest training opportunities for them. Urge them to meet with HR, conduct informational interviews in the company, or pitch you on a job redesign.
- ❑ Refresh their responsibilities so that their day-to-day work is better aligned with their larger aspirations.

To develop high-potential talent:

- ❑ Scope out the prospects for a high-potential employee's development in your company by talking to your boss and to other colleagues in the organization. What opportunities are available for someone with their talents?
- ❑ Talk to your high performers regularly about their stress levels and work-life balance: "This week has been very busy for you, and your performance at Thursday's meeting was fantastic. How are you feeling after all that? What do you need to recharge your batteries?"
- ❑ Recognize and embrace the need to validate high-potential talent on a regular basis. High achievers will respond favorably to recognition of their efforts.

To create stretch assignments:

- ❑ To evaluate an employee for a stretch assignment, ask yourself: Do they have what it takes? Is it the right opportunity? Can I secure it for them?
- ❑ Choose a sponsor to cosign your recommendation and prepare a pitch about why this person can succeed in the role, what your experience with them has been, and what risks the company assumes if the sponsor approves the assignment.
- ❑ Provide as much support as necessary to ensure the employee can shine in their stretch assignment. Check in regularly and support their success.